Submission Worksheet

Submission Data

Course: IT265-002-S2026
Assignment: IT265 Case Study - Personal Choice
Student: Joseph J. (jdj32)
Status: Submitted | **Worksheet Progress:** 100%
Potential Grade: 10.00/10.00 (100.00%)
Received Grade: 0.00/10.00 (0.00%)
Started: 4/27/2026 9:30:36 PM
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Grading Link: https://learn.ethereallab.app/assignment/v3/IT265-002-S2026/it265-case-study-personal-choice/grading/jdj32
View Link: https://learn.ethereallab.app/assignment/v3/IT265-002-S2026/it265-case-study-personal-choice/view/jdj32

Instructions

Step 1: Pick a game you plan to analyze

Step 2: Playtest your game choice (or review streamers playing the game)

Step 3: Analyze, research, and review your chosen game. Collect resources (website links, etc that you used during the exploration) include these with the responses in the related sections. Fill in the responses of the below prompts/checklist/etc.

Step 4: Export the PDF. Upload it to Github and upload the same PDF to Canvas.

Section #1: (1.25 pts.) Game Overview

Progress: 100%

Task #1 (0.63 pts.) - Historical Context and Game Description

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Game's title, developer, publisher, platform, and release date.
- Historical context of the game's release and its place in the industry.
- Game's genre and how it compares to similar games of the time.

Your Response:

Title: Slay the Spire Developer: Mega Crit Publisher: Mega Crit Platforms: Windows, macOS, Linux, Nintendo Switch, PlayStation 4, Xbox One, iOS, Android Release Dates:

- Windows, macOS, Linux: January 23, 2019
- PlayStation 4: May 21, 2019
- Nintendo Switch: June 6, 2019
- Xbox One: August 14, 2019
- iOS: June 13, 2020
- Android: February 3, 2021 Genre: Roguelike Deckbuilder

Slay the Spire was released at a time when the Roguelike Deckbuilder genre was not exactly a genre. Sure, there were games where, looking back, they fit into this category, but none were popular enough to spawn an entire genre. The game was relatively unique in its time; nothing similar to it really existed when it came out. Slay the Spire paved the way for other popular roguelike deckbuilders, such as Dicey Dungeons, Inscryption, Luck Be a Landlord, Backpack Hero, Balatro, and Slay the Spire II.

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Task #2 (0.63 pts.) - Gameplay Mechanics

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Discuss the core gameplay mechanics and how they shape the player's experience.
- Explain how players control the game and interact with it.
- Identify and describe any unique aspects or creative elements in the game's gameplay.

Your Response:

Slay the Spire is a roguelike deckbuilder where you move through a map of increasingly difficult encounters, using a deck of cards that you build along the way. You fight by drawing, discarding, and playing cards from your deck, using energy, and managing your health and block levels. The experience is shaped by risk vs reward gameplay, constant decision-making, and adaptability to the rewards you get. The game is controlled with point-and-click (or optionally keybinds) to choose the cards to use, who to attack, and menuing (shops, map, etc). The most unique aspect of this genre-defining game is the ability to build your deck throughout the game, adapting to the options that come your way, making the playthrough unique on every run.

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Section #2: (1.25 pts.) Software Architecture And Technology

Progress: 100%

Task #1 (0.63 pts.) - Technical Framework

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Describe the game engine and any special software (middleware) used to make the game. Explain why these were important for making the game work.
- List the programming languages and software tools used to build the game. Discuss how these tools helped in creating the game's features.

Your Response:

Slay the Spire was made in the LibGDX Java Framework. This framework was chosen as it would enable the game to run on multiple platforms, such as PC, Mac, and Linux, without needing to fully rewrite the code. The game is written primarily in Java, which was used to implement the core systems. With this and LibGDX for rendering, input handling, and audio systems, It allowed the indie dev team to build and maintain their game without the use of slower, larger game engines like Unity and Unreal.

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Slay_the_Spire
https://web.archive.org/web/20200122132036/https://www.gamasutra.com/view/news/356873/Road_to_tl
https://caseyyano.com/on-evaluating-godot-b35ea86e8cf4

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Task #2 (0.63 pts.) - Innovations and Challenges

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Identify and describe any new or unique technical features in the game. Explain how these features made the game different or improved it.
- Discuss any major difficulties the developers encountered while making the game. Describe how they solved these problems.

Your Response:

The most unique feature of Slay the Spire was the interactions between all the different cards, relics, and potions, and how they can Rue-Goldberg into being completely overpowered. Since Slay the Spire is a single-player game, there is no need to worry about strong combos feeling op, because you are the one playing the combos. With this, however, was also the largest difficulty. Ensuring that everything was balanced enough and fit together. Slay the Spire went through multiple years of playtesting and thousands of different card designs to make the game feel just right.

https://web.archive.org/web/20200122132036/https://www.gamasutra.com/view/news/356873/Road_to_tl

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Section #3: (1.25 pts.) Gameplay Mechanics And Level Design

Progress: 100%

Task #1 (0.63 pts.) - Mechanics Analysis

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Explore and describe the main rules and actions that players use in the game. Explain how these core mechanics define the game's playstyle.
- Discuss how the game's core mechanics keep players interested and involved. Describe the ways these mechanics make the game fun or challenging.

Your Response:

Slay the Spire is built around turn-based card battles on a branching map. In combat, players draw cards each turn, spend energy, and do actions like attacking, defending, or using specials. Between fights, they pick new cards, relics, shop, and choose which paths to follow to ultimately craft their deck into a boss-killing machine. The core mechanics keep players interested and engaged because of the randomness. You constantly need to be thinking and adapting to the options you are given in order to survive, and you need to be thinking ahead to what you need, what cards to cut from your deck, and more.

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Task #2 (0.63 pts.) - Level Design

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Describe the design of the game's levels or environments. Focus on the layout, obstacles, and visual elements, and how they contribute to the game's setting.
- Explain how the level or environment design affects the way players play the game. Discuss how these design choices impact the overall experience, such as creating challenges, guiding the player, or setting the mood.

Your Response:

Slay the Spire uses a branching nodes map instead of traditional level design. Each floor gives paths to enemy encounters, elite encounters, shops, random events, rest sites, and relic chests, all leading towards the floor boss. The obstacles come mostly

from player choice: do you take the harder routes for the better rewards, or do you take the easier routes with worse rewards? Take too many easy routes, and you won't be strong enough for the boss.

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Section #4: (1.25 pts.) Graphic And Audio Design

Progress: 100%

Task #1 (0.63 pts.) - Graphic and Audio Design

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Describe the game's visual appearance and the artistic choices made. Discuss elements like color, art style, and thematic consistency, and how they contribute to the game's overall look and feel.
- Discuss the design of the game's characters and environments. Focus on aspects such as realism, creativity, and how they fit within the game's world. Explain how these designs enhance the player's immersion in the game.

Your Response:

Slay the Spire uses a 2D, animated dark-fantasy design. Distinct colors are used to distinguish between game floors and player character types, helping distinguish different play scenarios. The game is stylized rather than realistic, leaning more towards clarity in mechanics, threats, and options to help better enable the player.

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Task #2 (0.63 pts.) - Audio Design

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Examine the game's sound design, focusing on the music and sound effects. Describe how they are used and their quality. Discuss any memorable or unique audio elements in the game.
- Explain how the game's audio contributes to its overall mood and setting. Discuss how sound and music influence the player's emotional response and enhance the gaming experience.

Your Response:

Slay the Spire has a rather simple audio design. Calm background music loops for each floor, providing ambiance while not disrupting the player's thinking and strategizing. Simple and clear sound effects are used, with distinct audio for any action the player can make to reinforce the purpose/effects of player actions. Nothing really stands out in the game audio, and that is intentional. The game tries and succeeds in providing a calm, strategic environment with its audio to help the player make the best decisions, and to not crowd the player with overwhelming amounts of sound effects.

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Section #5: (1.25 pts.) User Interface And User Experience

Progress: 100%

Task #1 (0.63 pts.) - User Interface and User Experience

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Describe the layout of the game's user interface (UI) and how it functions. Discuss elements like menus, icons, and on-screen prompts, and how they help players navigate and understand the game.
- Evaluate how well the game's UI communicates important information to players. Discuss aspects such as clarity, readability, and the ability of the UI to provide necessary game details without overwhelming or confusing the player.

Your Response:

Similar to the audio, the layout of the game's UI tries to be simple and clear, effectively communicating important game information while not overloading the player with too many decisions/too much information. The player's hand is shown at the bottom of the screen, enemies are displayed in the center, and HP, block, and energy information is clearly visible. Outside of combat, the map is simple, forward branching paths with nodes representing events marked by simple icons. Everything critically important to the player can be communicated at a glance at the screen, and more detailed information can be displayed by hovering over an item/card/enemy/etc.

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Task #2 (0.63 pts.) - UX Analysis

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Discuss the overall feel of playing the game, focusing on how different aspects of the game contribute to the player's experience. Analyze how these elements, such as ease of use, game flow, and feedback, affect the gameplay.
- Evaluate the design decisions made to enhance the player's experience. Consider factors like tutorial design, learning curve, and player engagement. Discuss how effective these choices are in making the game enjoyable and accessible to players.

Your Response:

Slay the Spire presents a very smooth and simple gameplay loop: move on the map, fight/special tile actions, collect rewards, repeat. The game's sound and visual effects provide incredibly effective and important feedback to the player, where information can be easily catalogued and processed to determine future game actions. The game doesn't really have a tutorial. It starts easier on the first couple of levels of floor 1, getting progressively harder as the floors increase until the final boss. It follows the try, die, repeat cycle of learning that many other roguelikes ascribe to, but it is not so difficult that you will feel like you are making no progress.

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Section #6: (1.25 pts.) Narrative And Storytelling

Progress: 100%

Task #1 (0.63 pts.) - Narrative Structure

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Describe the game's story, including its narrative structure, main plot points, and the setting in which it takes place. Discuss how these elements come together to create a cohesive and engaging story.
- Analyze the storytelling techniques used in the game, such as dialogue, cutscenes, or environmental storytelling. Evaluate how effectively these techniques convey the story and engage the player.

Your Response:

Slay the Spire has a very minimalistic story. You follow one of four different playable characters, chosen at the start of your run, as they attempt to climb through the multiple acts of the tower. The story is the climb itself: fight, loot, die, repeat, and it culminates at the end of your first successful run. Lore is hinted at through card descriptions, random events, enemy types, and more, but nothing is very overtly told to the player. The game implies a deeper story, and lets the player feel like they are in a

built-out world, but ain't nobody got time for that, you gotta strategize and win.

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Task #2 (0.63 pts.) - Character and Integration

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Discuss the development of the game's characters. Describe their roles within the story, their personalities, and how they evolve throughout the game. Consider how the characters contribute to the overall narrative.
- Examine how the game's narrative and characters are integrated into the gameplay. Discuss how story elements are woven into the game mechanics and how this integration affects the player's experience.

Your Response:

There are four playable characters in Slay the Spire: The Ironclad, The Silent, The Defect, and The Watcher. These characters don't have traditional story-driven roles, arcs, or personalities, but instead reveal themselves through their playstyles. They each have different main mechanics and card pools for deckbuilding, letting them each focus on a unique playstyle. They evolve through the game as you work with more of their card pool, showing their personalities through the actions they are able to take. This style of character development allows the player to become the character and choose how they develop, instead of the traditional cutscene naration.

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Section #7: (1.25 pts.) Impact And Reception

Progress: 100%

Task #1 (0.63 pts.) - Reception and Impact

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Research and summarize how the game was received by critics and players. Include key reviews, ratings, and player feedback. Discuss any notable praise or criticism the game received.
- Analyze the game's impact on the gaming industry. Discuss how it may have influenced game design, trends, or inspired other games. Consider any lasting effects it has had on the industry.

Your Response:

Slay the Spire was incredibly well-received by critics and players alike. It received an 89 Metacritic score, as well as a 97% positive rating on Steam with over 75 thousand reviews. It is praised as being the game that started/revitalized the roguelike deckbuilding genre. It had a huge impact on the game industry as a whole, inspiring many similar games, such as Inscription and Balatro, that more strictly follow the deckbuilding aspect. Additionally, many other games swapped the deck out for other methods of storing chosen items, such as a backpack for Backpack Hero, a slot machine for Luck be a Landlord, a pachinko machine for Peglin, and many, many more.

https://store.steampowered.com/app/646570/Slay_the_Spire/

https://www.metacritic.com/game/slay-the-spire/critic-reviews/?platform=pc

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Task #2 (0.63 pts.) - Cultural Significance

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Examine the game's cultural significance and the legacy it has left behind. Discuss how the game has been remembered over time and its status in the gaming community.
- Describe the game's presence and representation in media, such as films, books, or online content. Discuss its role in fan communities and any influence it has had on broader cultural aspects, such as art, music, or social trends.

Your Response:

Slay the Spire cements its legacy as one of the greats in indie game development. The game has been remembered as the game that popularized the roguelike deckbuilder genre, inspiring countless other roguelikes in kind. It has a large presence on YouTube and tight-knit communities of players on Discord, Reddit, and Twitch, all pushing each other to make crazier and crazier builds. The game is not represented in films or books, but a board game based on the original was released in 2024, and Slay the Spire 2 went into early access in March of this year.

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Section #8: (1.25 pts.) Reflection

Progress: 100%

Task #1 (0.63 pts.) - Describe your personal experience playing the chosen game

Progress: 100%

Details:

- Was it "fun"? What made it fun or not fun?
- Is this genre/game-type aligned with personal interests?
- What made you pick this game? Was it a good choice?

Your Response:

This game was incredibly fun. I am a huge fan of roguelikes, especially ones that involve strategy over technical skill, and having played this game before, I knew I would enjoy it again. I chose this game as it inspired the game I am currently prototyping, both physically and digitally. It was definitely a good choice, as analyzing it helped me understand how I can better improve the play of my game.

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Task #2 (0.63 pts.) - Assignment Reflection

Progress: 100%

Details:

- What interesting or new "thing(s)" did you learn during your research and analysis?
- Did you find it was easy to come across the information you were looking for? What was your primary means of research/analysis?

Your Response:

I was not familiar with the development aspect of this game, and learning what they used and why I think sheds some light on the aspects of my digital prototype I will need to focus on. Information on this game (outside of Wikipedia and its sources) was not incredibly easy to come by. I would attribute this to Slay the Spire being an indie game, and therefore not having much pre-release or mainstream attention in the gaming industry. Because of this, most useful information came from developer interviews and from actually playing the game.

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